Chain

By Pearl Cleage

(Pgs 28-52) *A loud scream. Sounds of scuffling, struggling, trying to escape and being caught. Only one voice is heard, ROSA JENKINS, a 16-year-old crack addict.*

DAY ONE

ROSA: *[Screaming, crying, pleading]* What are you doing? No! Stop It!! Don't, Daddy!! Please don't!! Stop it!! Wait, Daddy!! Wait! Don't do it! Please, don't do it! Daddy, Please! Please! Da-a-a-a-a-deeeeee!! *[sounds of struggle suddenly stop. A door slams and a deadbolt lock clicks loudly into place. Silence. ROSA is crumpled in the middle of the floor sobbing loudly]*

INTRODUCTION

Meet Rosa Jackson a sixteen-year-old crack addict whose parents have decided to take matters into their own hands. Their solution: keep their daughter chained inside their home for seven days. Will this desperate attempt to keep Rosa away from drugs and the violence of their Harlem neighborhood work? How far would you be willing to go to protect your child?

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ROSA: Mama? *[She listens intently and then speaks tentatively.]* Mama? Is that you? *[Listens again and then speaks angrily]* I hear you out there listening. What kind of mother are you? How can you let him do this to me? You don't love me! You never loved me!! You hate me! You all hate me!! *[Crumples again, sobbing. Stops suddenly and sits up. This time her look is more crafty. She is still listening.]* Mama? Mama are you still there? I didn't mean it, Mama. You know I didn't mean it. I know. you love me. I love you, Mama. *[Listens.]* Mama? Talk to me, Mama. Say something. Say anything!! *[Listens again.]* Well, don't then! I don't care what you do! You can't keep me in here if I don't want to stay! I'll get away just like I always do. You know I can do it, Mama!! And you know I will! How do you like that? *[Listens again. Suddenly frightened.]* Mama? Please let me out! I'm scared to be in here like this! Please let me out, Mama! I won't tell Daddy, I promise. He'll never know the difference. I won't go nowhere, I swear. I was just kiddin'. You can trust me, Mama. Honest! *[No sound at all from*

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outside. She is suddenly enraged.] Open this door and look at me! You scared to see me like this? *[Laughs crazily.]* Well, that's just too damn bad because you gotta deal with it. Look at me!

[ROSA lunges for the door and we see she is chained to the radiator with a long, thick chain -- shackled by her left foot. As she lunges, the chain jerks her back. She yelps in pain and falls down. She grabs the chain and tries to pull it off her leg, but she can't. She goes to the radiator and tries to pull the chain off the radiator, but she can't. She is like a caged animal and growls in a way that expresses wordless rage and frustration. She stands breathlessly looking around.]

DAY TWO

ROSA: Damn! *[frustrated and angry. She faces the audience and seems to see them for the first time. She is startled, but immediately takes on a craftiness.]* Got a match? *[holds up a cigarette.]* Hey! I'm talking to you! Y'all got a match? *[Disgusted at the lack of response.]* It ain't no reefer, okay? It's a Winston. Y'all probably don't smoke no way. Right? Lookin' out for your health. You probably wouldn't give me a damn match if you had it. *[A beat]* My dad told you not to talk to me, right? Not to listen to anything I said cuz I'm a dope fiend and I might trick you into doing something bad. *[Tosses cigarette aside. She moves restlessly around, touching the chain a lot. She is already feeling the effects of being deprived of the drug.]*

Think they can keep me chained up in here like some kind of freak. But that's where they wrong. I ain't no dumb dog! I can figure this out. Be back on the street before they get home from work tonight.

I wasted a lot of time yesterday. I mean, when I got home, they was actin' so glad to see me and now this? I slept all day Saturday. Next morning ... before they went to work, I came out to tell' em good-by and they sittin at the table talkin real quiet and they stop real fast when I come in. Then they look at each other and my dad pulls out a chair for me. They was lookin so serious, I thought they was gettin' ready to send me back to rehab and then my dad goes to the closet and pulls out this big bag and comes over and sits down beside me and hugs me and starts talking about how happy they were when I was first born and how I'll always be their daughter and they love me so much. Then I looked at Mama and she's

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cryin'. Mama ain't cried when I went to rehab since I was thirteen, so I know this is serious. I know this sounds crazy, but I thought they was gonna kill me. I could tell it was something heavy in the bag and I thought maybe Daddy had, like a sledgehammer, or something and they was gonna beat me to death and then put me in a bag and drop me in the river. *[Laughs.]* Crazy, right? Then Daddy takes out this big chain and I freaked.

Help! *[She waits. Listens. Then louder.]* Help!! *[Listening.]* Help, they're killin me! *[Listens -- Thinks for a minute.]* Fire! *[Listens. Still nothing.]* I could burn up and nobody would even know. I ought to have them arrested for doing this to me. *[A beat.]*

The first day we moved on this block, I was sittin on the stoop out front while Daddy moved our stuff inside and I was looking at this guy staggerin down the street, bumpin into people. I had never seen anybody that drunk before, so I was starin' at him. He hollered right in my face. I like died! New York is so different from Alabama it might as well be on another planet. When we got here, I was freaked out. My parents moved to New York so I could go to good schools and have better opportunities. Yeah, right. Opportunities to do what? I ain't complainin' though. It was exciting. I had never seen kids my age do what these New York *kids* were doing. They did everything. I mean eleven, twelve year old kids drinkin and smokin like they was grown already. It was like nobody had control of them or somethin. I didn't do none of that s*** for a long time. I was real goody goody. It was kind of a drag at first, but then I met Jesus (pronounced Hey-sus) and he hipped me to a lot about living in New York. Stuff I really needed to know, right? And plus, he was real fine and real cool and a Puerto Rican. Wadn't one Puerto Rican in Tuskegee, Alabama. Period. He thought I was Puerto Rican before he met me because my name was Rosa and someone told him I had a accent. He thought they meant a Spanish accent, but they was talkin about a Alabama accent. He thought that was real funny, too. I been knowin' Jesus since I was eleven years old.

Jesus mama had a boyfriend, right? And he was a crackhead and she hid his *stash* from him. Call herself tryin to help him get off it. Well, she wouldn't tell him where it was, so he

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shot her right there in their apartment, went through all her *stuff* until he found it, and was sittin there smokin it when Jesus came home. Jesus mama layin right on the floor in the next room, dead. Jesus say he didn't even tell him she was dead. He just looked up when he walked in and said, "Your mama in the kitchen." When Jesus came back out, he was gone. *[A beat.]*

So after they buried her, Jesus said he started thinkin about that crackhead just sittin there smokin while his mama layin in the next room dead and he said he just thought, If it's that good, let me have it. I told him he was just thinkin that way cause he felt bad about his mom but he said he wadn't askin' me if he should do it. He was just tellin' me. He didn't act like no addict either. He don't act like one now, unless he can't get it, then he start actin weird. Talkin crazy When Jesus need to get high, he talk about killin people a lot. He ain't never killed nobody, but he talk about it a lot when he can't get high. I know it's because of his mama, so I try to change the subject so he won't go off on it.

My Dad wanted to kill Jesus when he found out I was smokin crack, but I won't tell him where Jesus live. He act like it's Jesus' fault I'm smokin it. *[Laughs.]* I told you my dad be trippin! He never did like me to be around Jesus after what happen to Jesus mom.

DAY THREE

ROSA: *[A beat.]* Last night when they got home, my Mom was still cryin. They had both worked double shift, so it was late and they was worried about how I was gonna be when they got here. I started to layout like I was dead so when they opened the door they'd see me layin there with my eyes open. But I was just sittin here when they busted in all hyper. My Mom started huggin me and my Dad was lookin real relieved, right? They were scared I had figured a way to get out and wouldn't be here. They did unchain me while they were here, but then they followed me around. My mom even went in the bathroom with me, which was embarrassing. Then when we all got ready to go to bed, Daddy got this really sad look on his face, and put this chain right back on me like "this is hurting me more than it's hurting you." I hate when people say that to their kids. *[Laughs.]* I used to try to scream real loud when he would beat me so he'd feel bad and quit. I didn't even get my first

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whippin til I was thirteen. I kept runnin away from rehab and he didn't know what else to do. Me neither, so we lookin at each other like, well? And I'm thinkin, do somethin if you gonna do somethin or leave me alone so I can get high! So he took off his belt and hit me a couple of times, but it wadn't bad or nothin. My dad don't have the heart for that.

DAY FOUR

ROSA: My mom keeps tellin me to just take it one day at a time like they tell you in rehab. This is like a minute by minute trip, right? I want to get high so bad ... damn! My fingernails wanna get high. "One day at a time." *[In frustration, she begins to pull and tug at the chain in a rage.]* I'm not gonna make it. I'm gonna die all by myself. They're killin me. They're killin me. *[A beat, then trying to calm herself]* But it's gonna be okay. I just gotta hang in there til I'm eighteen, then they got no power over me no more. Jesus say when I get eighteen; I should move in wit him since he got plenty of room. I'm down wit it. I know Jesus dig me and he always got enough rock for us to get high. *[A beat, then ROSA yells several times in loud succession in complete frustration.]* I just wanna get high, you understand? I just need to get high. I need to get high!

DAY FIVE

ROSA: You know what's funny, I was almost glad to see my daddy when he came to get me. They told him if he didn't pay the hundred dollars owed them they'd blow my brains out right in front of him. My daddy just stood there for a minute lookin at that *guy* holdin his 9 millimeter against my head and I'm thinking, my daddy ain't got that kinda money! I'm dead! And then he reached in his pocket and took out a roll a money and handed it to the guy. He counted it right in front of my daddy and it was a hundred dollars exactly. Then he told my daddy to get his little crack addict outta his place and pushed me so hard I fell against his chest. My daddy didn't even look at me. He took off his jacket and put it around my shoulders and we walked the three blocks home with him holdin my arm like you do a little kid when they been bad. When we got home, my moms was there and she started cryin and holdin my face up so she could look at me. So I'm standin there and I catch a eye-ful of my pops sittin at the table and tears just runnin down his face. He ain't cryin or

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hollerin or nothin. He just sittin there lookin at me. That hurt me worse than anything. I never seen my daddy cry in my life. Never, I seen him mad plenty of times, but he never cried. He didn't cry when his momma died. Took the phone call, drove down south and buried her, came back and never broke. So I felt real bad when I saw him cryin over me. I love my daddy ... So I went over and stood in front of him and I said, don't worry about me, daddy. I'm okay. And he just looked at me and tears runnin all down his chin and started sayin my name over and over and over like he wasn't sure it was even me: Rosa, Rosa, Rosa!

DAY SIX

ROSA: *[She paces, but slowly -- thinking.]* My daddy say I been doin so good, he ask me was I worried about the street takin me back if he take the chain offa me. He sound so serious when he say that, but to me, he just be trippin. Like the street some kind of weird, scary thing waitin for you. So I told him no. I wasn't worried about the street takin me back. And he hug me and tell me there is nothin out there for me. I say, I know that's right. My pops told me I should pray instead of gettin high. No, He really did tell me that. I wish I believe in God, but I don't. It take time, my dad tell me. You have to get to know him just like any good friend. That's what he said. *[A beat.]* My daddy told me only God stronger than crack. I tell him this chain been doin a pretty good job. I was just kiddin, but I think it made him feel bad cause his face got all sad. *[A beat.]* He told me he knew I was a good girl and he trusted me. I wanted to say, hey, man! This is Harlem! Trust ain't in it! *[A beat.]* I don't trust nobody. *[She looks around.]* At least in here, ain't nobody *messin'* with me. I got food. I got a bathroom, so how bad can it be?

DAY SEVEN

[ROSA is rubbing her ankle distractedly and thinking. The chain is no longer on but she is still limping slightly. She speaks slowly and fiercely to herself]

ROSA: Okay, look. This is a prayer, okay? *[A beat.]* I can't do that s***.

[She is paces. She goes to the closet, slowly reaches in and gets the bag her dad had the chain in. She takes it out, handling it gingerly. There is both resignation and comfort in the chain. She places the shackle around her wrist like a bracelet. She takes it off but not away. She realizes what she is considering and the thought horrifies her. She looks at the chain for a beat and then reaches toward it again.]

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AWARD HISTORY

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